

The side door opened and Parry entered, his face beaming with pleasure as soon as he saw D'Arragnan.

'What is Rochester doing?' said the king.

'He is on the canal with the ladies,' replied Parry.

'And Buckingham?'

'He is there also.'

'That is well. You will conduct the chevalier to Villiers; that is the Duke of Buckingham, chevalier; and beg the duke to introduce M. d'Arragnan to the Princess Henrietta.'

Parry bowed and smiled to D'Arragnan.

'Chevalier,' continued the king, 'this is your parting audience; you can afterwards set out as soon as you please.'

'Sire, I thank you.'

'But be sure you make your peace with Monk!'

'Oh, sire—'

'You know there is one of my vessels at your disposal?'

'Sire, you overpower me; I cannot think of putting your majesty's officers to inconvenience on my account.'

The king slapped D'Arragnan upon the shoulder.

'Nobody will be inconvenienced on your account, chevalier, but for that of an ambassador I am about sending to France, and to whom you will willingly serve as a companion, I fancy, for you know him.'

D'Arragnan appeared astonished.

'He is a certain Comte de la Fère, —whom you call Athos,' added the king, terminating the conversation, as he had begun it, by a joyous burst of laughter. 'Adieu, chevalier, adieu. Love me as I love you.' And thereupon, making a sign to Parry to ask if there were any one waiting for him in the adjoining closet, the king disappeared into that closet, leaving the chevalier perfectly astonished by this singular audience. The old man took his arm in a friendly way, and led him towards the garden.

Chapter XXXV On the Canal



UPON the green waters of the canal bordered with marble, upon which time had already scattered black spots and tufts of mossy grass, there glided majestically a long, flat bark adorned with the arms of England, surmounted by a dais, and carpeted with long damasked stuffs, which trailed their fringes in the water. Eight rowers, leaning lazily to their oars, made it move upon the canal with the graceful slowness of the swans, which, disturbed in their ancient possessions by the approach of the bark, looked from a distance at this splendid and noisy pageant. We say noisy—for the bark contained four guitar and lute players, two singers, and several courtiers, all sparkling with gold and precious stones, and showing their white teeth in emulation of each other, to please the Lady Henrietta Stuart, grand-daughter of Henry IV, daughter of Charles I, and sister of Charles II, who occupied the seat of honour under the dais of the bark. We know this young princess, we have seen her at the Louvre with her mother, wanting wood, wanting bread, and fed by the coadjuteur and the parliament. She had, therefore, like her brothers, passed through an uneasy youth; then, all at once, she had just awakened from a long and horrible dream, seated on the steps of a throne, surrounded by courtiers and flatterers. Like Mary Stuart on leaving prison, she aspired not only to life and liberty, but to power and wealth.

The Lady Henrietta, in growing, had attained remarkable beauty, which the recent restoration had rendered celebrated. Misfortune had taken from her the luster of pride, but prosperity had restored it to her. She was resplendent, then, in her joy and her happiness,—like those hot-house flowers which, forgotten during a frosty autumn night, have hung

their heads, but which on the morrow, warmed once more by the atmosphere in which they were born, rise again with greater splendor than ever. Villiers, Duke of Buckingham, son of him who played so conspicuous a part in the early chapters of this history,—Villiers of Buckingham, a handsome cavalier, melancholy with women, a jester with men,—and Wilmot, Lord Rochester, a jester with both sexes, were standing at this moment before the Lady Henrietta, disputing the privilege of making her smile. As to that young and beautiful princess, reclining upon a cushion of velvet bordered with gold, her hands hanging listlessly so as to dip in the water, she listened carelessly to the musicians without hearing them, and heard the two courtiers without appearing to listen to them.

This Lady Henrietta—this charming creature—this woman who joined the graces of France to the beauties of England, not having yet loved, was cruel in her coquetry. The smile, then,—that innocent favour of young girls,—did not even lighten her countenance; and if, at times, she did raise her eyes, it was to fasten them upon one or other of the cavaliers with such a fixity, that their gallantry, bold as it generally was, took the alarm, and became timid.

In the meanwhile the boat continued its course; the musicians made a great noise, and the courtiers began, like them, to be out of breath. Besides, the excursion became doubtless monotonous to the princess, for all at once, shaking her head with an air of impatience,—‘Come gentlemen,—enough of this;—let us land.’

‘Ah, madam,’ said Buckingham, ‘we are very unfortunate! We have not succeeded in making the excursion agreeable to your royal highness.’

‘My mother expects me,’ replied the princess; ‘and I must frankly admit, gentlemen, I am bored.’ And whilst uttering this cruel word, Henrietta endeavoured to console by a look each of the two young men, who appeared terrified at such frankness. The look produced its effect—the two faces brightened; but immediately, as if the royal coquette thought she had done too much for simple mortals, she made a movement, turned her back on both her adorers, and appeared plunged in a reverie in which it was evident they had no part.

Buckingham bit his lips with anger, for he was truly in love with the Lady Henrietta, and, in that case, took everything in a serious light. Rochester bit his lips likewise; but his wit always dominated over his

‘A propos,’ continued Charles, ‘do you think my dear Monk has really pardoned you?’

‘Pardoned me! yes, I hope so, sire!’

‘Eh!—but it was a cruel trick! Odds fish! to pack up the first personage of the English revolution like a herring. In your place I would not trust him, chevalier.’

‘But, sire—’

‘Yes, I know very well Monk calls you his friend, but he has too penetrating an eye not to have a memory, and too lofty a brow not to be very proud, you know, *grande supcilium*.’

‘I shall certainly learn Latin,’ said D’Arragnan to himself.

‘But stop,’ cried the merry monarch, ‘I must manage your reconciliation; I know how to set about it; so—’

D’Arragnan bit his moustache. ‘Will your majesty permit me to tell you the truth?’

‘Speak, chevalier, speak.’

‘Well, sire, you alarm me greatly. If your majesty undertakes the affair, as you seem inclined to do, I am a lost man; the duke will have me assassinated.’

The king burst into a fresh roar of laughter, which changed D’Arragnan’s alarm into downright terror.

‘Sire, I beg you to allow me to settle this matter myself, and if your majesty has no further need of my services—’

‘No, chevalier. What, do you want to leave us?’ replied Charles, with a hilarity that grew more and more alarming.

‘If your majesty has no more commands for me.’

Charles became more serious.

‘One single thing. See my sister, the Lady Henrietta. Do you know her?’

‘No, sire, but—an old soldier like me is not an agreeable spectacle for a young and gay princess.’

‘Ah! but my sister must know you; she must in case of need have you to depend upon.’

‘Sire, every one that is dear to your majesty will be sacred to me.’

‘Very well—Parry! Come here, Parry!’

‘How much are you to give him?’

‘Oh!’ said D’Artagnan, ‘he is not a bad fellow; I shall arrange matters with him. I have had a great deal of trouble, you see, and expenses; all that must be taken into account.’

‘My dear friend, I can depend on you, and have no fear for the worthy Planchet; his interests are better in your hands than in his own. But now that you have nothing more to do here, we shall depart, if you please. You can go and thank his majesty, ask if he has any commands, and in six days we may be able to get sight of the towers of Notre Dame.’

‘My friend, I am most anxious to be off, and will go at once and pay my respects to the king.’

‘I,’ said Athos, ‘am going to call upon some friends in the city, and shall then be at your service.’

‘Will you lend me Grimaud?’

‘With all my heart. What do you want to do with him?’

‘Something very simple, and which will not fatigue him; I shall only beg him to take charge of my pistols, which lie there on the table near that coffer.’

‘Very well!’ replied Athos, imperturbably.

‘And he will not stir, will he?’

‘Not more than the pistols themselves.’

‘Then I shall go and take leave of his majesty. Au revoir!’

D’Artagnan arrived at St James’s, where Charles II, who was busy writing, kept him in the ante-chamber a full hour. Whilst walking about in the gallery, from the door to the window, from the window to the door, he thought he saw a cloak like Athos’s cross the vestibule; but at the moment he was going to ascertain if it were he, the usher summoned him to his majesty’s presence. Charles II rubbed his hands while receiving the thanks of our friend.

‘Chevalier,’ said he, ‘you are wrong to express gratitude to me; I have not paid you a quarter of the value of the history of the box into which you put the brave general—the excellent Duke of Albemarle, I mean.’ And the king laughed heartily.

D’Artagnan did not think it proper to interrupt his majesty, and he bowed with much modesty.

heart, it was purely and simply to repress a malicious smile. The princess was then allowing the eyes she turned from the young nobles to wander over the green and flowery turf of the park, when she perceived Parry and D’Artagnan at a distance.

‘Who is coming yonder?’ said she.

The two young men turned round with the rapidity of lightning.

‘Parry,’ replied Buckingham; ‘nobody but Parry.’

‘I beg your pardon,’ said Rochester, ‘but I think he has a companion.’

‘Yes,’ said the princess, at first with languor, but then, — ‘What mean those words, “Nobody but Parry;” say, my lord?’

‘Because, madam,’ replied Buckingham, piqued, ‘because the faithful Parry, the wandering Parry, the eternal Parry, is not, I believe, of much consequence.’

‘You are mistaken, duke. Parry—the wandering Parry, as you call him—has always wandered in the service of my family, and the sight of that old man always gives me satisfaction.’

The Lady Henrietta followed the usual progress of pretty women, particularly coquettish women; she passed from caprice to contradiction;—the gallant had undergone the caprice, the courtier must bend beneath the contradictory humour. Buckingham bowed, but made no reply.

‘It is true, madam,’ said Rochester, bowing in his turn, ‘that Parry is the model of servants; but, madam, he is no longer young, and we laugh only when we see cheerful objects. Is an old man a gay object?’

‘Enough, my lord,’ said the princess, coolly; ‘the subject of conversation is unpleasant to me.’

Then, as if speaking to herself, ‘It is really unaccountable,’ said she, ‘how little regard my brother’s friends have for his servants.’

‘Ah, madam,’ cried Buckingham, ‘your royal highness pierces my heart with a dagger forged by your own hands.’

‘What is the meaning of that speech, which is turned so like a French madrigal, duke? I do not understand it.’

‘It means, madam, that you yourself, so good, so charming, so sensible, you have laughed sometimes—smiled, I should say—at the idle prattle of that good Parry, for whom your royal highness to-day entertains such a marvellous susceptibility.’

‘Well, my lord, if I have forgotten myself so far,’ said Henrietta, ‘you do wrong to remind me of it.’ And she made a sign of impatience. ‘The good Parry wants to speak to me, I believe: please order them to row to the shore, my Lord Rochester.’

Rochester hastened to repeat the princess’s command; and a moment later the boat touched the bank.

‘Let us land, gentlemen,’ said Henrietta, taking the arm which Rochester offered her, although Buckingham was nearer to her, and had presented his. Then Rochester, with an ill-dissembled pride, which pierced the heart of the unhappy Buckingham through and through, led the princess across the little bridge which the rowers had cast from the royal boat to the shore.

‘Which way will your highness go?’ asked Rochester.

‘You see, my lord, towards that good Parry, who is wandering, as my lord of Buckingham says, and seeking me with eyes weakened by the tears he has shed over our misfortunes.’

‘Good heavens!’ said Rochester, ‘how sad your royal highness is to-day; in truth we seem ridiculous fools to you, madam.’

‘Speak for yourself, my lord,’ interrupted Buckingham with vexation; ‘for my part, I displease her royal highness to such a degree, that I appear absolutely nothing to her.’

Neither Rochester nor the princess made any reply; Henrietta only urged her companion more quickly on. Buckingham remained behind, and took advantage of this isolation to give himself up to his anger; he bit his handkerchief so furiously that it was soon in shreds.

‘Parry, my good Parry,’ said the princess, with her gentle voice, ‘come hither. I see you are seeking me, and I am waiting for you.’

‘Ah, madam,’ said Rochester, coming charitably to the help of his companion, who had remained, as we have said, behind, ‘if Parry cannot see your royal highness, the man who follows him is a sufficient guide, even for a blind man; for he has eyes of flame. That man is a double-lamped lantern.’

‘Lighting a very handsome martial countenance,’ said the princess, determined to be as ill-natured as possible. Rochester bowed. ‘One of those vigorous soldiers’ heads seen nowhere but in France,’ added the princess, with the perseverance of a woman sure of impunity.

‘What have you done with yours, seeing that it has not made you a miser or a prodigal? For avarice dries up the heart, and prodigality drowns it—is that not so?’

‘Fabricius could not have spoken more justly. But in truth, my money has never been a burden to me.’

‘How so? Do you place it out at interest?’

‘No; you know I have a tolerably handsome house; and that house composes the better part of my property.’

‘I know it does.’

‘So that you can be as rich as I am, and, indeed, more rich, whenever you like, by the same means.’

‘But your rents,—do you lay them by?’

‘No.’

‘What do you think of a chest concealed in a wall?’

‘I never made use of such a thing.’

‘Then you must have some confidant, some safe man of business who pays you interest at a fair rate.’

‘Not at all.’

‘Good heavens! what do you do with it, then?’

‘I spend all I have, and I only have what I spend, my dear D’Arragnan.’

‘Ah! that may be. But you are something of a prince; fifteen or sixteen thousand livres melt away between your fingers; and then you have expenses and appearances—’

‘Well, I don’t see why you should be less of a noble than I am, my friend; your money would be quite sufficient.’

‘Three hundred thousand livres! Two-thirds too much!’

‘I beg your pardon—did you not tell me?—I thought I heard you say—I fancied you had a partner—’

‘Ah! Mordieux! that’s true,’ cried D’Arragnan, colouring; ‘there is Planchet. I had forgotten Planchet, upon my life! Well! there are my three hundred thousand livres broken into. That’s a pity! it was a round sum, and sounded well. That is true, Athos; I am no longer rich. What a memory you have!’

‘Tolerably good; yes, thank God!’

‘The worthy Planchet!’ grumbled D’Arragnan; ‘his was not a bad dream! What a speculation! Peste! Well! what is said is said.’

which from the coffers of the king had passed into his coffers, from passing from his coffers into the pockets of any thief whatever. The best means discovered by the Gascon was to inclose his treasure, for the present, under locks so solid that no wrist could break them, and so complicated that no master-key could open them. D'Aragnan remembered that the English are masters in mechanics and conservative industry; and he determined to go in the morning in search of a mechanic who would sell him a strong box. He did not go far; Master Will Jobson, dwelling in Piccadilly, listened to his propositions, comprehended his wishes, and promised to make him a safety lock that should relieve him from all future fear.

'I will give you,' said he, 'a piece of mechanism entirely new. At the first serious attempt upon your lock, an invisible plate will open of itself and vomit forth a pretty copper bullet the weight of a mark—which will knock down the intruder, and not with a loud report. What do you think of it?'

'I think it very ingenious,' cried D'Aragnan; 'the little copper bullet pleases me mightily. So now, sir mechanic, the terms?'

'A fortnight for the execution, and fifteen hundred livres payable on delivery,' replied the artisan.

D'Aragnan's brow darkened. A fortnight was delay enough to allow the thieves of London time to remove all occasion for the strong box. As to the fifteen hundred livres—that would be paying too dear for what a little vigilance would procure him for nothing.

'I will think of it,' said he; 'thank you, sir.' And he returned home at full speed; nobody had yet touched his treasure. That same day Athos paid a visit to his friend and found him so thoughtful that he could not help expressing his surprise.

'How is this?' said he, 'you are rich and not gay—you, who were so anxious for wealth!'

'My friend, the pleasures to which we are not accustomed oppress us more than the griefs with which we are familiar. Give me your opinion, if you please. I can ask you, who have always had money: when we have money, what do we do with it?'

'That depends.'

Rochester and Buckingham looked at each other, as much as to say,—
'What can be the matter with her?'

'See, my lord of Buckingham, what Parry wants,' said Henrietta. 'Go!'

The young man, who considered this order as a favour, resumed his courage, and hastened to meet Parry, who, followed by D'Aragnan, advanced slowly on account of his age. D'Aragnan walked slowly but nobly, as D'Aragnan, doubled by the third of a million, ought to walk, that is to say, without conceit or swagger, but without timidity. When Buckingham, very eager to comply with the desire of the princess, who had seated herself on a marble bench, as if fatigued with the few steps she had gone,—when Buckingham, we say, was at a distance of only a few paces from Parry, the latter recognized him.

'Ah! my lord!' cried he, quite out of breath, 'will your grace obey the king?'

'In what, Mr. Parry?' said the young man, with a kind of coolness tempered by a desire to make himself agreeable to the princess.

'Well, his majesty begs your grace to present this gentleman to her royal highness the Princess Henrietta.'

'In the first place, what is the gentleman's name?' said the duke, haughtily.

D'Aragnan, as we know, was easily affronted, and the Duke of Buckingham's tone displeased him. He surveyed the courier from head to foot, and two flashes beamed from beneath his bent brows. But, after a struggle,—*'Monsieur le Chevalier d'Aragnan, my lord,'* replied he, quietly.

'Pardon me, sir, that teaches me your name, but nothing more.'

'You mean—'

'I mean I do not know you.'

'I am more fortunate than you, sir,' replied D'Aragnan, 'for I have had the honour of knowing your family, and particularly my lord Duke of Buckingham, your illustrious father.'

'My father?' said Buckingham. 'Well, I think I now remember. *Monsieur le Chevalier d'Aragnan, do you say?'*

D'Aragnan bowed. 'In person,' said he.

'Pardon me, but are you one of those Frenchmen who had secret relations with my father?'

‘Exactly, my lord duke, I am one of those Frenchmen.’

‘Then, sir, permit me to say that it was strange my father never heard of you during his lifetime.’

‘No, monsieur, but he heard of me at the moment of his death: it was I who sent to him, through the hands of the valet de chambre of Anne of Austria, notice of the dangers which threatened him; unfortunately, it came too late.’

‘Never mind, monsieur,’ said Buckingham. ‘I understand now, that, having had the intention of rendering a service to the father, you have come to claim the protection of the son.’

‘In the first place, my lord,’ replied D’Artagnan, phlegmatically, ‘I claim the protection of no man. His majesty, Charles II, to whom I have had the honour of rendering some services—I may tell you, my lord, my life has been passed in such occupations—King Charles II, then, who wishes to honour me with some kindness, desires me to be presented to her royal highness the Princess Henrietta, his sister, to whom I shall, perhaps, have the good fortune to be of service hereafter. Now, the king knew that you at this moment were with her royal highness, and sent me to you. There is no other mystery, I ask absolutely nothing of you; and if you will not present me to her royal highness, I shall be compelled to do without you, and present myself.’

‘At least, sir,’ said Buckingham, determined to have the last word, ‘you will not refuse me an explanation provoked by yourself.’

‘I never refuse, my lord,’ said D’Artagnan.

‘As you have had relations with my father, you must be acquainted with some private details?’

‘These relations are already far removed from us, my lord—for you were not then born—and for some unfortunate diamond studs, which I received from his hands and carried back to France, it is really not worth while awakening so many remembrances.’

‘Ah! sir,’ said Buckingham, warmly, going up to D’Artagnan, and holding out his hand to him, ‘it is you, then—you whom my father sought everywhere and who had a right to expect so much from us.’

‘To expect, my lord, in truth, that is my forte; all my life I have expected.’ At this moment, the princess, who was tired of not seeing the stranger approach her, arose and came towards them.

Chapter XXXIV Of the Embarrassment of Riches



D’ARTAGNAN lost no time, and as soon as the thing was suitable and opportune, he paid a visit to the lord treasurer of his majesty. He had then the satisfaction to exchange a piece of paper, covered with very ugly writing, for a prodigious number of crowns, recently stamped with the effigies of his very gracious majesty Charles II.

D’Artagnan easily controlled himself: and yet, on this occasion, he could not help evincing a joy which the reader will perhaps comprehend, if he deigns to have some indulgence for a man who, since his birth, had never seen so many pieces and rolls of pieces juxtaposed in an order truly agreeable to the eye. The treasurer placed all the rolls in bags, and closed each bag with a stamp sealed with the arms of England, a favour which treasurers do not grant to everybody. Then, impassible, and just as polite as he ought to be towards a man honoured with the friendship of the king, he said to D’Artagnan:

‘Take away your money, sir.’ Your money! These words made a thousand chords vibrate in the heart of D’Artagnan, which he had never felt before. He had the bags packed in a small cart, and returned home meditating deeply. A man who possessed three hundred thousand livres can no longer expect to wear a smooth brow; a wrinkle for every hundred thousand livres is not too much.

D’Artagnan shut himself up, ate no dinner, closed his door to everybody, and, with a lighted lamp, and a loaded pistol on the table, he watched all night, ruminating upon the means of preventing these lovely crowns,

D'Aragnan took it, and turning gravely towards Monk: 'I have still asked too little, I know,' said he, 'but believe me, your grace, I would rather have died that allow myself to be governed by avarice.'

The king began to laugh again, like the happiest cockney of his kingdom.

'You will come and see me again before you go, chevalier?' said he; 'I shall want to lay in a stock of gayety now my Frenchmen are leaving me.'

'Ah! sire, it will not be with the gayety as with the duke's sword; I will give it to your majesty gratis,' replied D'Aragnan, whose feet scarcely seemed to touch the ground.

'And you, comte,' added Charles, turning towards Athos, 'come again, also; I have an important message to confide to you. Your hand, duke,' Monk pressed the hand of the king.

'Adieu! gentlemen,' said Charles, holding out each of his hands to the two Frenchmen, who carried them to their lips.

'Well,' said Athos, when they were out of the palace, 'are you satisfied?'

'Hush!' said D'Aragnan, wild with joy, 'I have not yet returned from the treasurer's—a shutter may fall upon my head.'

'At least, sir,' said Buckingham, 'you shall not wait for the presentation you claim of me.'

Then turning towards the princess and bowing: 'Madam,' said the young man, 'the king, your brother, desires me to have the honour of presenting to your royal highness, Monsieur le Chevalier d'Aragnan.'

'In order that your royal highness may have, in case of need, a firm support and a sure friend,' added Parry. D'Aragnan bowed.

'You have still something to say, Parry,' replied Henrietta, smiling upon D'Aragnan, while addressing the old servant.

'Yes, madam, the king desires you to preserve religiously in your memory the name and merit of M. d'Aragnan, to whom his majesty owes, he says, the recovery of his kingdom.' Buckingham, the princess, and Rochester looked at each other.

'That,' said D'Aragnan, 'is another little secret, of which, in all probability, I shall not boast to his majesty's son, as I have done to you with respect to the diamond studs.'

'Madam,' said Buckingham, 'monsieur has just, for the second time, recalled to my memory an event which excites my curiosity to such a degree, that I shall venture to ask your permission to take him to one side for a moment, to converse in private.'

'Do, my lord,' said the princess; 'but restore to the sister, as quickly as possible, this friend so devoted to the brother.' And she took the arm of Rochester, whilst Buckingham took that of D'Aragnan.

'Oh! tell me, chevalier,' said Buckingham, 'all that affair of the diamonds, which nobody knows in England, not even the son of him who was the hero of it.'

'My lord, one person alone had a right to relate all that affair, as you call it, and that was your father; he thought it proper to be silent, I must beg you to allow me to be so likewise.' And D'Aragnan bowed like a man upon whom it was evident no entreaties could prevail.

'Since it is so, sir,' said Buckingham, 'pardon my indiscretion, I beg you; and if, at any time, I should go into France—' and he turned round to take a last look at the princess, who took but little notice of him, totally occupied as she was, or appeared to be, with Rochester. Buckingham sighed.

'Well?' said D'Aragnan.

'I was saying that if, any day, I were to go to France—'

'You will go, my lord,' said D'Artagnan, 'I shall answer for that.'

'And how so?'

'Oh, I have strange powers of prediction; if I do predict anything I am seldom mistaken. If, then, you do come to France?'

'Well, then, monsieur, you, of whom kings ask that valuable friendship which restores crowns to them, I will venture to beg of you a little of that great interest you took in my father.'

'My lord,' replied D'Artagnan, 'believe me, I shall deem myself highly honoured if, in France, you remember having seen me here. And now permit—'

Then, turning towards the princess: 'Madam,' said he, 'your royal highness is a daughter of France; and in that quality I hope to see you again in Paris. One of my happy days will be on that on which your royal highness shall give me any command whatever, thus proving to me that you have not forgotten the recommendations of your august brother.' And he bowed respectfully to the young princess, who gave him her hand to kiss with a right royal grace.

'Ah! madam,' said Buckingham, in a subdued voice, 'what can a man do to obtain a similar favour from your royal highness?'

'Dame! my lord,' replied Henrietta, 'ask Monsieur d'Artagnan; he will tell you.'



TAKING IT BY THE POINT HE PRESENTED IT TO THE KING

The eyes of D'Artagnan regained their gayety and their brilliancy. The Gascon began to understand. Charles advanced towards him.

'The general,' said he, 'is not rich, and cannot pay you what he is worth. I am richer, certainly; but now that he is a duke, and if not a king, almost a king, he is worth a sum I could not perhaps pay. Come, M. d'Artagnan, be moderate with me; how much do I owe you?'

D'Artagnan, delighted at the turn things were taking, but not for a moment losing his self-possession, replied, — 'Sire, your majesty has no occasion to be alarmed. When I had the good fortune to take his grace, M. Monk was only a general; it is therefore only a general's ransom that is due to me. But if the general will have the kindness to deliver me his sword, I shall consider myself paid; for there is nothing in the world but the general's sword which is worth as much as himself.'

'Odds fish! as my father said,' cried Charles. 'That is a gallant proposal, and a gallant man, is he not, duke?'

'Upon my honour, yes, sire,' and he drew his sword. 'Monsieur,' said he to D'Artagnan, 'here is what you demand. Many have handled a better blade; but however modest mine may be, I have never surrendered it to any one.'

D'Artagnan received with pride the sword which had just made a king.

'Oh! oh!' cried Charles II.; 'what a sword that has restored me to my throne—to go out of the kingdom—and not, one day, to figure among the crown jewels! No, on my soul! that shall not be! Captain d'Artagnan, I will give you two hundred thousand livres for your sword! If that is too little, say so.'

'It is too little, sire,' replied D'Artagnan, with inimitable seriousness.

'In the first place, I do not at all wish to sell it; but your majesty desires me to do so, and that is an order. I obey, then, but the respect I owe to the illustrious warrior who hears me, commands me to estimate a third more the reward of my victory. I ask then three hundred thousand livres for the sword, or I shall give it to your majesty for nothing.' And taking it by the point he presented it to the king. Charles broke in to hilarious laughter.

'A gallant man, and a merry companion! Odds fish! is he not, duke? is he not, comte? He pleases me! I like him! Here, Chevalier d'Artagnan, take this.' And going to the table, he took a pen and wrote an order upon his treasurer for three hundred thousand livres.



'WHAT CAN A MAN DO TO OBTAIN A SIMILAR FAVOUR FROM YOUR ROYAL HIGHNESS?'

throne, that I might say to you, as to Louis XIV, my brother! Oh! I have it; and you will almost be my brother, for I make you viceroy of Ireland and Scotland, my dear duke. So, after that fashion, henceforward I shall not make a mistake.'

The duke seized the hand of the king, but without enthusiasm, without joy, as he did everything. His heart, however, had been moved by this last favour. Charles, by skilfully husbanding his generosity, had given the duke time to wish, although he might not have wished for so much as was given him.

'Mordieux!' grumbled D'Artagnan, 'there is the shower beginning again! Oh! it is enough to turn one's brain!' and he turned away with an air so sorrowful and so comically piteous, that the king, who caught it, could not restrain a smile. Monk was preparing to leave the room, to take leave of Charles.

'What! my trusty and well-beloved!' said the king to the duke, 'are you going?'

'With your majesty's permission, for in truth I am weary. The emotions of the day have worn me out; I stand in need of rest.'

'But,' said the king, 'you are not going without M. d'Artagnan, I hope.'

'Why not, sire?' said the old warrior.

'Well! you know very well why,' said the king.

Monk looked at Charles with astonishment.

'Oh! it may be possible; but if you forget, you, M. d'Artagnan, do not.' Astonishment was painted on the face of the musketeer.

'Well, then, duke,' said the king, 'do you not lodge with M. d'Artagnan?'

'I had the honour of offering M. d'Artagnan a lodging; yes, sire.'

'That idea is your own, and yours solely?'

'Mine and mine only; yes, sire.'

'Well! but it could not be otherwise—the prisoner always lodges with his conqueror.'

Monk coloured in his turn. 'Ah! that is true,' said he; 'I am M. d'Artagnan's prisoner.'

'Without doubt, duke, since you are not yet ransomed; but have no care of that; it was I who took you out of M. d'Artagnan's hands, and it is I who will pay your ransom.'